

Crowning moment: The victorious Mumbai team with the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy after sealing a 175-run chase against Madhya Pradesh with 13 balls to spare. K. MURALIKUMAR



KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS WILL BE A HAPPY BUNCH. HAVING GONE UNSIGNED IN THE FIRST ROUND, AJINKYA RAHANE – NAMED THE PLAYER OF THE SERIES – WAS A TERRIFIC VALUE FOR MONEY PICK AT RS 1.5 CRORE

Shedge who stole the show in the summit clash. The 21-year-old walked in to bat when Mumbai felt the heat. Shedge, however, went about his business like a veteran finisher, carting the attack to all parts for an unbeaten 15-ball 36.

The timing of the tournament was a disservice to the players. With the 2025 IPL auction completed just two days into SMAT, grand performances in this tournament went without reward. Take the case of Chandigarh fast bowler Jagjit Singh, the highest wicket-taker. The 27-year-old got the ball to move around and hit the right lengths to trouble all batters. And yet, he remains without an IPL contract.

MP spinner Kumar Kartikeya is only slightly better off. With 17 wickets, he stood behind Jagjit in the wickets chart. A wrist spinner with

plenty of variations, Kartikeya had the established Mumbai batters on the ropes. If the IPL auction was held later this month, Kartikeya could have fetched a far better deal than the base price of Rs 30 lakh he received from Rajasthan Royals.

Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) will be a happy bunch. Having gone unsigned in the first round, Rahane — named the Player Of The Series — was a terrific value for money pick at Rs 1.5 crore. Rahane is sure to play a big part in KKR's IPL 2025 campaign.

The final at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium witnessed a massive turnout. This is quite rare for a domestic match at this venue, which usually only sees a handful of passionate supporters seated in a

far corner.

This time around, the stadium was more than half full, which made for an electric atmosphere. The Karnataka State Cricket Association (KSCA) made the right decision to open nearly all gates to accommodate the constant inflow of enthusiastic spectators.

Patidar gained the maximum support, but there was plenty of cheer for the big names from Mumbai as well.

Shreyas was surprised to see the large number of fans fill the seats. "Whenever we play at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium, the crowds are electrifying. The way they came in huge numbers today — it was out of this world. I was not expecting it. I initially saw one stand fully packed at the start of the match. But later on, once the match picked up pace, the numbers increased, and it went bonkers. We know how much the people of Bengaluru love their RCB players, but I'm happy that they supported us as well," Shreyas said.